THEORY LAB · 03

“What and How describe; only Why explains.”

The most quoted sentence in this literature.

Most people who quote it have not noticed what it costs them.

FOUR BUILDING BLOCKS

The anatomy of a theory

1 WHAT, which factors belong? Comprehensiveness against parsimony.

2 HOW, how are they related? “Using arrows to connect the boxes.”

3 WHY, what dynamics justify the factors and the arrows? “The theoretical glue that welds the model together.”

4 WHO, WHERE, WHEN, the boundary conditions. Where does it hold, and where does it stop?

WHETTEN'S VOCABULARY

The terms that became the field's shorthand

Domain

What and How together, the factors and the relations between them. The territory a theory claims, before any explanation is offered.

The theoretical glue

Whetten's phrase for Why: the underlying psychological, economic or social dynamics that justify both the factors and the arrows.

Boundary conditions

Who, Where, When. The circumstances under which the theory holds, and, more usefully, where it stops.

Reorganizing the causal map

His test for whether a change counts. Adding a variable qualifies only if it significantly alters how the phenomenon is understood.

THE LINE THAT CHANGES WHAT YOU OWE

“During the theory-development process, logic replaces data as the basis for evaluation.”

In a theory paper you are not being asked to prove the relationships. You are being asked to make them make sense.

Whetten pushes further: “If all links have been empirically verified, the model is ready for the classroom and is of little value in the laboratory.”

A DOCUMENTED CASE

Two flying machines with the same What and a different Why

In 1903 Samuel Langley and the Wright brothers were building the same list of parts: wings, a light engine, propellers, a frame. Langley worked with roughly $70,000 of War Department and Smithsonian money. The Wrights worked out of a bicycle shop on a fraction of it.

Langley's Why was power: a machine fails because the engine is not strong enough. The Wrights' Why was control: a machine fails because the pilot cannot hold it steady in three axes. Langley's Aerodrome went into the Potomac twice that autumn. The Wrights flew on 17 December.

Same factors. Same relations. A different account of why the thing works, and that difference is the entire contribution.

Crouch, T. D. (1989). The Bishop's Boys. Norton. Funding figures are the standard historical estimates and are approximate.

HOW MUCH IS ENOUGH?

Changing one element is almost never a contribution.

Most scholars improve existing theories rather than building new ones. So Whetten asks what counts.

Adding a variable qualifies only if it “significantly alters our understanding of the phenomena by reorganizing our causal maps.”

A new moderator in an old model is a What-change. It is not, on its own, a Why-change.

DO THIS NOW

Write your contribution beginning with the word “Because.”

“Because X operates through Y, the relationship reverses when Z”, that is a Why.

“Because prior research has not examined this population”, that is a gap, and a gap is not a reason.

If you cannot get past the second form, you have a What.

SOURCES

Whetten, D. A. (1989). What constitutes a theoretical contribution? Academy of Management Review, 14(4), 490–495.

Bacharach, S. B. (1989). Organizational theories: Some criteria for evaluation. AMR, 14(4), 496–515.

Weick, K. E. (1989). Theory construction as disciplined imagination. AMR, 14(4), 516–531.

Crouch, T. D. (1989). The Bishop's Boys: A life of Wilbur and Orville Wright. Norton.

An honest limit: the four blocks describe a variance model well. They fit process theories awkwardly and interpretive work barely at all. Weeks 13–16 are about what happens when the framework meets work it was not built for.

THE QUESTION

Can you write your contribution as one sentence beginning “Because”?

If it runs “Because prior research has not examined...”, you have a What, not a Why.

Next Saturday: Weick on where a Why comes from, and why most theorists only ever generate one.

Post your sentence in the comments